Supporting the Teacher Team

Teaching an emergent curriculum such as The Restaurant is complex work. Teachers must incorporate students' experiences and interests as the study evolves, and they must also find ways for students to actively explore and engage with concepts that are driven by curricular goals. As the study progresses, they must reflect on and refine their approach, and look for interdisciplinary connections. And, in order to facilitate this type of learning for their students, they must contend with a variety of logistics, such as organizing and conducting field trips, recruiting parent volunteers, deciding on a menu, obtaining the food, arranging the classroom furniture for the restaurant, and many others. Supporting teachers in this work requires engaging with them in all the conceptual, instructional, and logistical aspects of their teaching. Peggy McNamara supported the first-grade teachers, Sarah and Kristin, as a coach while they planned, implemented, and reflected on The Restaurant.

Patrons of The Happy Café sit around the table and read the menus.

Building from Where the Teachers Are

Peggy's deep knowledge of elementary school children and teachers guided her work with the team in significant ways. An example of this was her insight that teachers needed a coach who could focus on their pressing concerns, offer support in addressing them, and, at the same time, push them to think more deeply about their practice and consider their pedagogy from new perspectives. When the teachers first began planning The Restaurant, she found them preoccupied with figuring out how they would fit all the field trips and the restaurant days into an already jam-packed school calendar. When Peggy asked them where they were in their planning process, Sarah told her, "I think we need to plan out the rest of the school year. We need to know the dates of the field trips and the dates for the restaurant days. We don't have dates yet." Rather than seeing this focus on logistics as a distraction from bigger curricular questions, Peggy knew that the teachers needed to start their work by sorting these issues out. She said to the group, "Do you want to backwards plan the restaurant days? This is when we can do it." This decision resulted in helping the teachers take ownership of their process, and strengthened their belief that she was there to support them, not to press her own agenda. Later, when Peggy raised some questions about how the

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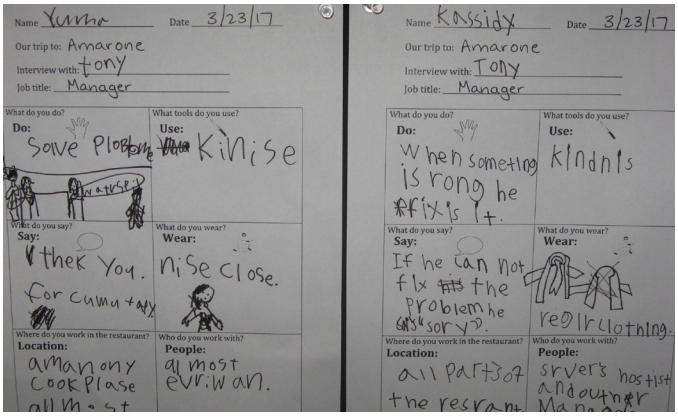
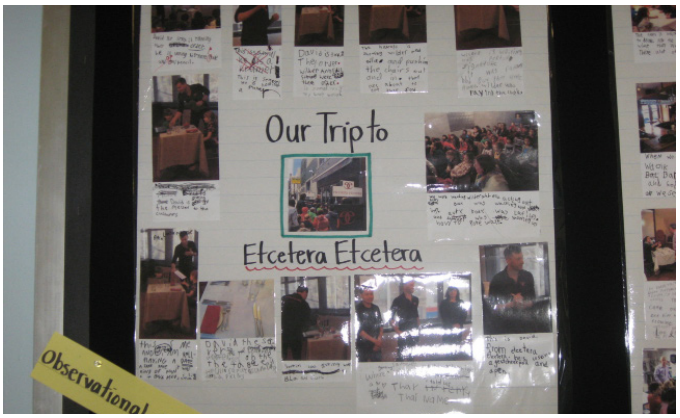


Student work on what they experienced and witness on their trips to local restaurants.

teachers might more fully incorporate science into their unit, the teachers were poised to be receptive and heed suggestions because of the rapport that Peggy had carefully built with them.

Asking Open-Ended, but Purposeful, Questions

Peggy did not position herself as an evaluator of the teachers' practice. Instead, she acted as a critical friend who listened carefully, made observations, and asked open-ended questions to push the conversation deeper. Her suggestions to the teachers came after a probing discussion, in which Peggy was striving to really understand the perspective of the teachers. In one meeting, Peggy pressed the teachers to think more about how science content would be integrated into The Restaurant. At the beginning of the conversation, the teachers told Peggy that as a homework assignment, they had asked the children to walk through their neighborhood and choose a favorite restaurant. The students were asked to write about that restaurant and bring their writing to school. Kristin explained that this was part of the science curriculum. Peggy asked, "How is it science?" Sarah replied, "It was the introduction to the What is Food? portion of the study." Peggy responded with a suggestion that pushed the teachers to think about more science angles from which they could approach the What is Food? portion of the study, "Another question you might ask the students is, What time of day do we eat something?" Later, when the teachers began to discuss how they would engage the children in food preparation, she pushed them to consider the science behind cooking. Because she knew the teachers were less comfortable with science content than other subjects, she scaffolded the discussion by asking, "So what are the ways that food changes when we prepare it? What happens when we cut, mix, boil or bake foods?" This question required the teachers to reach beyond the activity planning stage and think about the concepts that children could learn through preparing foods.



The class conducted research in preparation for the opening of The Happy Café by visiting the restaurant, Etcetera Etcetera.

Modeling

Beyond building trust and rapport with the teachers, Peggy's open-ended questioning style also modeled for the teachers and their student teachers how to assume an inquiry stance in relation to their practice. Rather than judging their practice, she asked questions. Rather than making a standard set of suggestions, she led with questions that called for aspirational or imaginative responses. This was important because it helped teachers see their relationships with children and the learning environment as sites for continual renewal and growth. In one example, Peggy modeled for Sarah's student teacher how she might reflect on her work with the children to prepare food. Following up on an earlier conversation, Peggy noted that the

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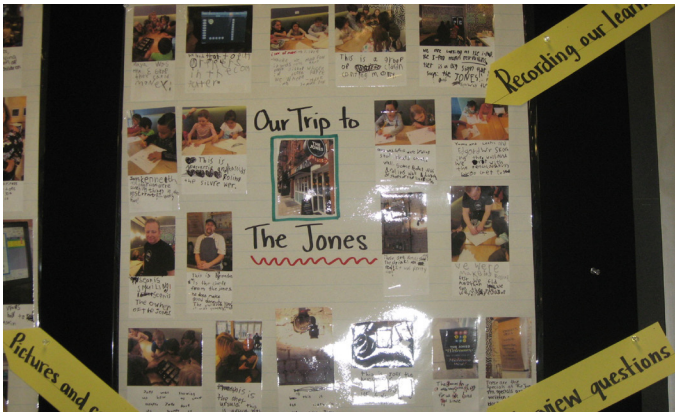
class had created a poster that described the process of boiling an egg. "I see all this happened," she said, pointing to the poster. "What did you learn from doing this with the children?" Peggy consistently noted evidence of the work the teachers were doing in the classroom, asked questions about it, and emphasized the learning that the teachers were doing. This modeled for both the teachers and their student teachers that teaching was never a completed enterprise, but rather one which required ongoing self-examination. Despite her many years of teaching and coaching experience, Peggy positioned herself as a learner - seeking to understand the teachers and students in these particular classes. Through her own example, she communicated an expectation that teachers are always learning.

Providing Resources

From early in the planning stage for The Restaurant, Peggy and the teachers discussed how they might better incorporate science into the study. Peggy knew that the teachers were less comfortable with science than they were with other aspects of the curriculum, and, therefore, it would require an intentional emphasis in their meetings. During each of the meetings, Peggy acknowledged what the teachers had already done to incorporate science into the curriculum, and then pushed forward to planning new ways to integrate science. She also developed resources and drew upon her networks to help facilitate the teachers' professional development. To help prepare the teachers for cooking with the children as a means of understanding the properties of food, she said, "I sent you a brainstorm of how you might approach science the way we've been doing social studies. At this point we have a sense of what are different foods. The second question could be about categorizing food by times of day. And, then, how do we prepare food? I think you are ready to come up with one, and do one. I don't think it is enough to just talk about it." Later, Peggy reflected on her work with the Hall of Science and drew from a project on which she was collaborating there to think of more connections between The Restaurant and food science. This demonstrated the multiple roles Peggy donned as a coach, which included acknowledging their hard work and the complexity of teaching, modeling an inquiry disposition, pushing them to think harder and more deeply about content and pedagogy, and connecting them to a larger community of educators and resources to strengthen their practice.



The class took pictures and wrote down their descriptions of the trips that they took to local restaurants in preparation for the opening of The Happy Café.